

TOPIC . . . COMMENT

(From David Pesetsky)

Dear Editor,

A recent article by Susan Rothstein 'Case and NP Licensing' (*NLLT* 10: 119–139) argues that a proposal from my dissertation be rejected. I had suggested that selection for syntactic categories (which I dubbed "c-selection") be reduced to two factors: semantic selection ("s-selection") and the stipulated ability or inability of a given verb to license objective Case. With my proposal, s-selection by both *ask* and *wonder* in principle allows both NP and CP complementation, but the possibility of an NP object for *wonder* is eliminated by a stipulation that *wonder* does not assign accusative Case.

Rothstein argues, in contrast, that we should return (for now, at least) to the assumption that c-selectional properties of predicates are simply listed in the lexicon, as in *Aspects*. Though her argument against the actual text of my dissertation is quite valid, she is, I think, too hasty to dispose of the conceptual baby merely because of some incidental inadequacies of my Case-theoretic bathwater.

Rothstein's central criticism (p. 131) concerns the fact that a verb which on my hypothesis is marked [–Case] may nonetheless license an accusative object in a resultative construction. Thus, although *complain*, *worry* and *reason* all allow CP complementation and disallow NP complementation in the normal case (**He complained their leaving*), these verbs all permit an object NP in the resultative construction (*He complained himself hoarse about the bad coffee*). In fact, with a bit of work, these data fall nicely within the theory of Case developed in the very chapter that contains the discussion criticized by Rothstein. Earlier in that chapter, I argued that accusative Case assignment to arguments should be distinguished from accusative Case assignment to non-arguments, which is not so limited. My evidence for this was the Russian accusative of duration, which genitivizes under negation like direct objects, but occurs freely with any aspectually appropriate verb.

Nonetheless, looking back on that discussion in the context of Rothstein's article, a more explicit and more interesting proposal can be advanced. As I also noted in that chapter, verbs which lexically require oblique Case (e.g., dative) require this Case to be realized on an argumental object to the exclusion of any other expected case. (This idea was dubbed by Babby and Freidin in a slightly later article the 'Principle of Lexical Satisfaction'.) Verbs that require oblique-marked objects, I went

on to point out, do *not* extend this requirement to non-arguments, which remain accusative. For that reason, I proposed that quirky Case requirements are closely linked to theta-marking – a now-familiar property of “inherent” or “quirky” case.

Suppose we see the distinctive property of *complain* not as an inability to license accusative Case, but as a special instance of a quirky Case requirement – a requirement that the thematic object of *complain* bear no (morphological) Case whatsoever. Let us call this property “selection for (quirky) zero Case. Immediately, we expect non-thematic objects of *complain* to be immune from this quirky Case requirement. Thus, we are not surprised to see *caseless* CP objects successfully theta-marked by *complain*. (I will leave open the question whether quirky zero Case is the same as *null Case* for PRO, recently discussed by Chomsky and Lasnik). The spirit of my earlier suggestions is fully preserved, but the slightly more nuanced technology skirts Rothstein’s objections.

These ideas also give us some handle on a fact noted by Rothstein in criticism of Pesetsky (1982), but not otherwise explained. WH-trace is sometimes acceptable where an NP object is not. We know that WH-trace may sometimes differ in its Case properties from its antecedent, as in the phenomenon of Ancient Greek Case attraction once much discussed in the literature. I remain with no *account* of why *what I’m wondering t is . . .* differs from **what I’m complaining t is . . .*, but we at least have a way to think about the problem. Similarly, where passivization of a zero Case predicate is possible, we are no longer dealing with passivization of a verb that fails to license Case. Finally, Burzio’s generalization (as discussed by Rothstein) remains a generalization over Case-licensing in general, orthogonal to whether a verb requires quirky Case (now including zero Case) or not, as required by Rothstein’s data.

When criticizing some proposal P, it is of course important to deal adequately with P, but it is often equally helpful to consider the family of proposals that includes P. In the present case, this led us to a proposal a scant millimeter removed from that in my dissertation, but with coverage equivalent to Rothstein’s alternative. This seems to me a good thing, since Rothstein’s alternative involves a return to a theory whose conceptual and empirical problems were noted in my dissertation. On the other hand, where problems remain for Rothstein, they remain for my proposal as well. Thus, the book is far from closed on the question of c-selection and s-selection, and we would be wrong to assume otherwise.

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DAVID PESETSKY

Dept of Linguistics and Philosophy, Massachusetts Institute of Technology
Cambridge, MA 02139, U.S.A.